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INTERVIEW

50 METRES, THREE POSITIONS, ONE DESTINY

Sift Kaur Samra's shots are being heard around the globe, as the world record holder is back on the leaderboard. Will she be able to exorcise the ghosts of the past?

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Sift Kaur Samra has the vibe of any other 23-year-old. A Bollywood buff, her heart beats for lo-fi music, distant horizons, and untold adventures.

She also swoons over puppies and swears by Italian platters at Chandigarh's Virgin Courtyard. Her carefree demeanour is the very antithesis of the mental image we have of champion shooters.

But at the shooting range, a quiet focus takes over. As her eyes lock onto the target 50 metres away, her fingers are steady, and breath measured. Not even a smile escapes her lips, even when her .22-calibre bullet hits 10.9.

For a marathon discipline like 50m rifle 3 positions (3P), you need to display extraordinary levels of core strength, zen-like concentration, and above all, mental fortitude. Sift checks all the boxes. It's almost as if she's

found the Powerpuff Girls' Chemical X hidden away in an obscure corner of Professor Utonium's cabinet.

Sift set a world record at the 2023 Asian Games with a score of 469.6, surpassing Seonaid McIntosh's mark by 2.6 points. The record may not stand the test of time like javelin legend Jan Železný's, who traced the arc of immortality with his throw of 98.48m almost 30 years ago, but Sift has already done her bit to reiterate that Indian shooting no longer merely takes part in marquee tournaments to make up the numbers.

In a country where world records in any sport are hard to come by, Sift's story is one that many relate to.

A dreamy-eyed girl sets out to become a doctor. Fast forward to 2019, and she's traded the stethoscope for a rifle at the 50m range.

Almost miraculously, it takes her only four years to set a world record. Naturally, she is seen smiling across four columns of all newspapers the next day. Endorsements roll in. She becomes an overnight sensation

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